

NEW CHAPTER
Dhanush and Kriti Sanon in *Tere Ishk Mein*; (inset) director Aanand L. Rai

kar is all about uncalculated love. "They say girls tend to grow up faster and be more mature, and maybe in relationships, too, they are able to understand a little before the boy whether it will work or not," adds Rai. "It may be perceived as losing certain emotions, but maybe it is knowing how to control them."

Spanning a decade in the life of Shankar and Mukti, it's the former who has invited scrutiny for his angry, aggressive avatar. Rai wants the audience to see the film before drawing conclusions. "At one point, my hero was Manu (R. Madhavan in *Tanu Weds Manu*), who was not at all an alpha male. In fact, the girl was alpha. Nobody asked me why are you making the girl like this—smoking , drinking and enjoying."

Rai feels his latest love story is mature, intense and also "fearless". "With every film, I just pray to God that I should have the guts to tell the story I want to. It shouldn't be like *yeh banaata hoon, yeh chalti hai* [let's make this, this sells]," he says. This one's already set tongues wagging. ■

—Suhani Singh



ZERO (2018)
Rai's first collaboration with a mega star in Shah Rukh Khan failed at the box office, but its ambition—a quirky love story built around a hero with dwarfism—was unmistakable.

CINEMA ▼

STEPPING INTO THE LIMELIGHT

The record-breaking success of *Lokah Chapter 1: Chandra* has turned Kalyani Priyadarshan's vampire-superhero character into a cultural phenomenon

A superhero film about an emotionally aloof female vampire is an ingenious idea on paper, but it's also a box-office gamble. Few could have predicted that the idea would result in the highest-grossing Malayalam film of all time and resonate way beyond Kerala.

Leading lady Kalyani Priyadarshan is still basking in the glory of *Lokah Chapter 1: Chandra* which recently released on JioHotstar. "We all [thought] that this is very experimental. It could go either way," she admits.

Daughter of popular filmmaker Priyadarshan, Kalyani studied architecture and began her cinematic journey behind the camera, interning with production designer Sabu Cyril. Surprisingly, Priyadarshan didn't want either of his two kids to follow in his footsteps. "I've seen my father go through ups and downs. Parents don't want the kids to experience what they have been through," she says. That first conversation as she informed him of her desire to be an actor and the nerves she felt are still vivid in her mind. "He was supportive," she adds. "He felt I had clarity."

Kalyani opted to kick off her on-screen journey with Telugu films. "I was proud that I was working in an industry that my dad didn't have a foot in," she says. In 2020, she made her Malayalam debut with *Varane Avashyamund*. "It was a great stepping stone. I have made best friends with the people who made it and I still go to them for advice," she says. Dulquer, her co-star in it and also the film's producer, would go on to produce *Lokah* too.

Lokah's success has led to much excitement over the emergence of India's own superhero universe, one that is rooted in Indian folklore and legends. Even as Kalyani cannot wait to slip into Chandra's costume again, she is already building up her resume, having wrapped two Tamil films and currently working on another "small" one. "It's very different from *Lokah*. Most of it happens in a house," she says. She's open to Bollywood, provided it's a script she enjoys. And if *Lokah*'s success is anything to go by, Kalyani knows that good films speak and succeed regardless of the language they are told in. ■

—Suhani Singh



RISING STAR
Kalyani says she's open to Bollywood provided it's a script she enjoys

ESHAAN GIRRI